

Holywood 1604

Chap. I — The Sectaries' marks, and the first reason against them (libellus pp. 2–4)

They say, then, that the Church has certain definite marks or properties, which accompany her back through the ages, and set her in the clearest and, as it were, noonday light (to use Whitaker's words): and that these marks or properties are the pure preaching of the word of God and the legitimate administration of the Sacraments: and that thus — just as a body is known from quantity, an animal from sense, a man from the power of reasoning, and all other things, finally, from the affections proper to their natures — so the church is rightly sought from these marks, and found with certainty. Which indeed seems a very honorable speech. But alas for the grief, alas for the outrage: we are entering a labyrinth; and while we think we are gazing upon the shining Sun, we are wrapped in the densest fog. Wretched, therefore, are they who have set these men before themselves as guides to be followed; they roll the stone of Sisyphus: they can labor, they cannot rest; they can seek, they cannot find. And how true this is, a threefold reason demonstrates.

First: in order that the disciples of the Sectaries might come, through these marks, to the knowledge of the true Church, their masters would have to define the sincere preaching of the word of God and the legitimate administration of the Sacraments in such a way that you could from it determine with certainty who is a member of the true Church and who is not. But on this definition nothing settled is to be found among them. [marg. *In the Defense of the Apology, part 1, p. 48.*] Hence the ministers of the Anglican Church, who preach that their Parliamentary congregation is the bride of Christ, when they seek their brethren by these traces, stumble most shamefully, and expose themselves most foolishly to the laughter of all. Jewel makes a brother of Berengarius, who agrees on the Eucharist alone while dissenting on the rest: therefore, if we listen to him, whoever sides with the Parliamentarians in some one thing (understand: against the Church) certainly preaches the word of God and legitimately administers the Sacraments. What could be more rotten than this? Nor may you say that the Eucharist has something peculiar to it for discerning the genuine sons of the Church. For Jewel does not banish from his congregation the Lutherans, whose faith concerning the Eucharist he nevertheless condemns utterly as erroneous. Whitaker makes enemies of the Puritans, but fellow-citizens of those who followed the form prescribed by the Parliament of the year 1540 under Henry VIII: yet the Puritans admit only two Sacraments, with Whitaker and the present Anglican Church; whereas the protestants of the Parliament held under Henry had at least three in use (for they had not yet abjured auricular confession, or the Sacrament of penance), and accordingly were accustomed to burn as manifest heretics those who denied that the true body of Christ is really contained in the Eucharist — as the new protestants of this kingdom deny. You will say, perhaps, that by Puritans Whitaker means the Cathars, ancient heretics (as I remember a certain foolish minister saying); but that is far and away most false; for he speaks of those into whom, as Reginaldus says, very many protestants

of England have lately degenerated, so much so that every province abounds with them: he speaks of those whom Dr. Whitgift harries in his defense. But these are not Cathars, but a new and well-known sect, that hates the very name of Bishop.

CHAPTER II. A brief and sure rule is handed down for knowing which is the true Church of God (libellus pp. 9–12)

We must therefore proceed by another way: namely through things conceded by and known to all, or at least proved evidently by suitable arguments. And lest I weary the reader with long expectation: I assume, first, that a true church existed in the time of the Apostles. No one will deny this, and it rests on luminous testimonies of the sacred scriptures; whence Whitaker says that in the Apostles' time all Churches, all cities, all towns, all families cultivated the same faith and religion which the Parliamentarians now profess; and the other sectaries are accustomed to say the same of themselves.

I assume, 2, that this Church was a heterogeneous body, that is, one consisting of members of diverse kinds: such that some were superiors, others subjects; some pastors, others sheep; some endowed with the power of directing and coercing, others bound by the necessity of obeying and complying. On this point no sectary of any name will contend: And it is proved most manifestly from the scriptures, Acts 20: *Take heed to yourselves and to the whole flock, wherein the Holy Ghost hath placed you bishops, to rule the Church of God, which he hath purchased with his own blood.* Hebr. 13: *Obey your prelates, and be subject to them, for they watch as being to render an account for your souls.* And 1 Cor. 4: *What will you? shall I come to you with a rod, or in charity and in the spirit of meekness?*

I assume, 3, that this Church, or heterogeneous body, so differentiated, has endured from the time of the Apostles down to our own age, and will endure hereafter until the end of the world [the print reads *fidem mundi*, a misprint for *finem mundi*]: this is luminously expressed in Ephes. 4: *And he gave some apostles, and some prophets, and other some evangelists, and other some pastors and doctors, for the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, unto the edifying of the body of Christ: until we all meet into the unity of faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the age of the fulness of Christ: that henceforth we be no more children, and be not carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the wickedness of men, by cunning craftiness unto the circumvention of error: for by these words we are taught that pastors and doctors, for the continual edification of the body of Christ and the preservation of its members in the sincerity of the faith, will be in the Church always, until the day of judgment.* Which Jerome, taking as beyond doubt, writes thus in his disputation against the Luciferians: *I shall offer you the brief and open judgment of my mind: that we must remain in that Church which, founded by the Apostles, endures down to this very day.* And that the frank confession of our adversaries may not be lacking: Whitaker teaches in express words that the true and Catholic Church of Christ cannot fail: And Calvin, that at no time whatever can she be without pastors and doctors.

I assume, 4, that the people who lived in the time of the Apostles, together with those who followed their times and will follow hereafter, make one Church through continuous succession: as the water which is in the riverbed today, with that which was there yesterday, makes one river. For thus are those things fitted by nature to have the unity of which we speak, which do not exist together at the same time, but at different times.

I assume, 5, that the succession of pastors (from whom judgment is passed concerning the people) comes about, in the Church of Christ, through the visible propagation of the later from the earlier. Thus the Apostles, created pastors by Christ, substituted others in their own place: and these, by the Apostles' prescription, others in turn. Acts 14: *And when they had ordained to them priests in every church.* 1 Tim. 4: *Neglect not the grace that is in thee... by the imposition of my hands.* 1 Tim. 5: *Impose not hands lightly upon any man, neither be partaker of other men's sins.* To Titus 1: *For this cause I left thee in Crete, that thou shouldest set in order the things that are wanting, and shouldest ordain priests in every city, as I also appointed thee.* On account of these things Calvin writes thus, Institutes book 4, chapter 3, number 6: *Although no certain precept concerning the imposition of hands is extant, yet because we see that it was in perpetual use with the Apostles, that so careful an observance of theirs ought to stand to us in place of a precept.* And below: *This, lastly, is to be held: that it was not the whole multitude that imposed hands on its ministers, but the pastors alone.*

I assume, 6, that the pastors who in subsequent centuries succeeded the Apostles, and the pastors created immediately by the Apostles, are to be sought directly from trustworthy history. For history is the witness of the times: and the sacred scriptures, in their manner of narration, do not proceed beyond the times of the Apostles.

These things being laid down, I conclude that that one is to be established for certain as the true Church of Christ which, through trustworthy history, can rightly derive her legitimate succession from the Apostles. This follows perspicuously from the premises, and Augustine understood it brilliantly when he says: *There holds me in the Catholic Church, from the very see of Peter the Apostle (to whom the Lord commended his sheep to be fed) down to the present Bishop, the succession of Priests.* [marg. *Against the Epistle of the Foundation, chap. 4.*]

It remains, therefore, that applying this rule to use, we inquire faithfully by it which, of the so many congregations today bearing the faith of Christ before them, is his true bride. And if any scruple should arise concerning the things we have said thus far, it will be dispatched in what follows. And since this whole kingdom of England (for whose benefit this our industry toils) is, as to religion, distributed into roughly three classes — namely catholics, protestants, and puritans — we shall treat of these three only.

Chap. VI. The adversaries' arguments are answered — Objections 2–4 (libellus pp. 23–28)

You will object, 2: Great variety is found in the numbering of Peter's successors; therefore the succession of the supreme pontiffs is uncertain. The antecedent is evident: for in the first place after Peter some put Linus, others Clement; and in the second place some set Cletus, some Clement, some Anacletus.

I answer that the argument proves only that there is some uncertainty about the order of the succession, but about the succession itself not at all: for on that all agree. So of the death of Christ no Christian doubts, although among authors there is no small contention about the year: some holding that Christ suffered in the 30th year of his age, others the 33rd, others finally the 34th. Now the true order of the pontiffs is this: Peter, Linus, Cletus, Clement, to whom succeeded Anacletus. So the most ancient canon of the Mass, so the Roman Martyrology, so Epiphanius, heresy 27, and Jerome, in the book on ecclesiastical writers, under Clement. Nor is Irenaeus to be judged foreign to this enumeration, even though he joins to Linus not Cletus but Anacletus. For he, on account of the similarity of name, thought Anacletus the same as Cletus: as did also Optatus of

Milevis (whom Augustine follows) and Epiphanius: of whom the latter for that reason omits Anacletus, the former Cletus. That some set Clement immediately after Peter is thought to have come about from this: that Peter, as his martyrdom drew near, chose and ordained Clement his successor, as Tertullian relates in the book *De praescriptione*, and others; although, Peter being dead, Clement refused to sit for a full twelve years, yielding, so long as they lived, to Linus and Cletus, who had been the helpers of blessed Peter himself in the episcopal office — as is gathered from the fragment of the same Clement's epistle in Epiphanius above, which runs thus: *I withdraw, I depart; let the Church of God be built up*. Nor ought the pontifical authority of Damasus, Sophronius, and Metaphrastes move us, who relate that Linus died before Peter: for Sophronius and Metaphrastes are more recent; and that book ascribed to Damasus is little consistent with itself, as Baronius proves. [marg. *Annals*, tome 1, year 69.]

You will object, 3: Various changes are found in the election of the supreme pontiff. For Peter chose his own successor; at one time the Roman clergy had the right of electing; now the Cardinals alone elect. I answer that by divine law nothing on this matter is found determined in particular: and thence it is understood that the whole business was left by Christ to the prudence of the church. Wherefore, that she uses now one mode of electing, now another, as the variety of the times and the reckoning of the common good seem to demand, in no way impairs the election.

You will object, fourth: The Church is like the Moon, and accordingly now shines whole, now is deprived of part of her light, now shows no light at all, as Whitaker teaches in answer to Campion's third reason. Therefore, although the sectaries, when one comes to those times in which the whole Church was oppressed with darkness and utterly destitute of light, find no pastors to whom they might join themselves, they are not on that account to be censured, as if they did not belong to the Church. I answer that nowhere in the sacred scriptures, nor in any approved author, have I read that the church changes like the moon — but indeed that the fool changes like the moon; which tells strongly against this doctor, who in one and the same place teaches that the church endures perpetually, and has certain essential properties (these are never separated from the thing) which set her in the clearest and, as it were, noonday light; and yet that she is sometimes deprived of all light. I answer, secondly, that it was demonstrated above that the church, compounded of pastors and sheep, has endured from the time of the Apostles down to the present day; and in such wise that the later pastors succeeded the earlier perpetually and visibly; wherefore to maintain that this church was at some time invisible is to trifle gratuitously. Where it is to be observed that we are not now disputing about any other church. Nor does what Whitaker brings forward in patronage of his error avail — that under the reign of Achab the remnants of the old visible church survived in Elias alone, and that Christ said thus of ours: *When the Son of man cometh, shall he find, think you, faith on earth?* For the former is a most stupid lie: since in the whole kingdom of Juda the Synagogue shone most brightly at that time; just as, when Aaron sinned in the worship of the calf, and others too, Moses, the head of that church, did not fail, nor the Levites. And the latter has no place except at the coming of Christ — which one must distinguish from the coming of Calvin and of Whitaker.

There is added that Jerome and the other fathers, answering the heretics of their own time, understand that saying to be spoken of that faith of which elsewhere: *If you have faith as a grain of mustard seed, you shall say to this mountain, Remove from hence, and it shall remove*. Nay, even if with Theophylact you should wish to interpret it otherwise, you still cannot say that there will be no faithful in the time of Antichrist, or so few that they do not make a visible church; as is plain from Paul, Ephes. 4. Whence it is clear how that is to be expounded which stands in 2 Thessal. 2 (and is also urged by Whitaker), that before the coming of Christ the revolt shall come first; provided by the revolt you do not

understand, with Chrysostom, Oecumenius, Theodoret, Theophylact, and Augustine, Antichrist himself, or, with Ambrose, Sedulius, and Primasius [printed *Priuasio*], the defection from the Roman Empire — but the Apostasy from the faith. For it must not be supposed that Christ will desert the visible Church, but that many will fall away from the church to the side of Antichrist, whether through nobility of intellect or through fear of persecution, others meanwhile strenuously championing the cause of Christ — just as now comes to pass in England. Further, that saying of Jerome — *The whole world groaned, and marveled to find itself Arian* — which some bring in objection, regards the Bishops who at Ariminum, deceived by the Arians, decreed that the term ὁμοούσιος should be removed; and it does little harm. For those Bishops did not consent to the Arian heresy, since they had not seen through the force of the word (as Whitaker himself confesses); just as Jacob did not consent to fornication when Lia was put in his place instead of Rachel. Nor indeed does it stand against us that the Synagogue is now abolished: for our church was bound to succeed it, but no other church on earth succeeds ours.

More of the adversaries' dirges looking this way you may see in Bellarmine and in others who have treated these things more fully. Here it pleases us only to show, in the matter under discussion, that Whitaker is the genuine son of the old heretics, and we of the holy fathers. Thus, then, the Donatists in Augustine, concerning the visible Church of their own day: *That Church which once was of the Gentiles now is not; it has perished; the Scriptures are fulfilled; all the Gentiles have believed; but the Church of all the Gentiles has apostatized and perished.* This is what Whitaker says in other words: *The mystery of iniquity at length occupied the whole Church, and she became plainly Antichristian.* Augustine adds, in these words of the Donatists: they say that the mainstay of the Apostasy of the whole earth is that which is said: *the Son of man, when he cometh, shall he find, think you, faith on earth?* But to these things the most holy Doctor, as if replying, says: *Shall perhaps that city which the world once feared be overthrown? Far be it. God hath founded her for ever. And Christ says: I am with you even to the consummation of the world.* And since the Donatists twisted these and similar testimonies to themselves, whom they called the Lord's portion: he refutes them, from the fact that God does not speak of a few sectaries, but of that Church of which it is said in psalm 101: *When the peoples assemble together into one, and kingdoms to serve the Lord.* Hence you see from whom Whitaker learned to say that the Catholic church cannot fail, but the Roman (that is, the church which, dispersed through the world, is subject to the Roman Pontiff) can. And he says it for this reason: that, while he is not of the Church, he may nevertheless seem to the less prudent a nursling of the Church — the very thing Augustine reproved in the Donatists.

Chap. VI. — Objections 5–6, and the rule confirmed (libellus pp. 28–31)

You will object, fifth: The Greek Church is not the true Church, and yet she shows a succession from the Apostles: therefore the Church is not proved from succession. The rule for knowing the Church handed down above is therefore not fit. A certain author, not without repute, answers that legitimate succession is adduced principally to prove that the Church is not there where this succession is not, which is evident; but that it is not necessarily inferred that the Church is there where succession is. And he adds that in the Greek Church no certain succession can be shown. But assuredly the old fathers were accustomed, against the heretics of their age, to point out the Church from the succession of the Roman pontiffs, as all know. Yet they tacitly understood, or added, something as noted, which rendered the argument valid. So Tertullian, when he had said of the heretics:

Let them therefore produce the origins of their Churches: let them unroll the order of their Bishops, running down by successions from the beginning in such wise that that first Bishop had for author or predecessor some one of the Apostles or of the Apostolic men — he added — *yet one who persevered with the Apostles.* [marg. *De praescriptione haereticorum.*] I answer, therefore, that the greeks, though [their Church] show a succession, are not of the Church; and yet that it is not rightly inferred from this that our rule does not hold. The first is proved: For the Greeks were legitimately convicted, in three plenary Councils — the Lateran, that of Lyons, and that of Florence — of schism and heresy, and chiefly of that by which they deny that the Holy Ghost proceeds from the Son: which the Parliamentarians and Puritans confess to be manifest heresy. Wherefore they are manifestly cut off from the mystical body of Christ. The second also is proved: For our rule is not content with bare succession; but demands besides that one derive his legitimate succession from the Apostles rightly; and he does not derive it rightly who is publicly cut off.

You will object, sixth: For the Church there is required not only a succession of pastors, but also a succession of doctrine: and therefore the old fathers, who point out the Church from the succession of the Roman pontiffs, do so because in those times it was evident to all that the faith and religion had not been changed in the Roman Church. Now, as to the latter part of the argument: I answer that this gloss is utterly empty. For it is well established that the heretics with whom the fathers disputed contended that the Roman Church had even then failed, apostatized, erred in doctrine — just as our adversaries now will have her corrupted. Whence is that saying of Augustine: *What has the chair of the Roman Church done to thee, in which Peter sat, and in which Anastasius now sits? why callest thou the chair of Peter the chair of pestilence?* And that of Optatus: *Whence is it that you Donatists strive to usurp to yourselves the keys of the kingdom — you who war against the chair of Peter with your presumptions and with sacrilegious audacity?* The fathers therefore urged the succession of Bishops, which the heretics could not deny, taking from the succession the judgment to be passed concerning the Church, and from the Church concerning the doctrine. Hear Irenaeus: *By pointing to the tradition which that greatest and most ancient Church, known to all, founded and constituted at Rome by the two most glorious Apostles Peter and Paul, has from the Apostles, and to the faith announced to men, coming down even to us through the successions of Bishops, we confound all those who, in whatever manner, whether through evil self-pleasing, or vainglory, or through blindness and evil opinion, gather otherwise than they ought.* Hear likewise Augustine: *Number the Priests even from the very see of Peter, and in that order of Fathers see who succeeded whom. She herself is the rock which the proud gates of Hell do not conquer.* [marg. *In the psalm against the party of Donatus.*]

Now to the former part, I say: it is true indeed that integrity of doctrine is always conjoined with the Church of Christ, as the tide with the Ocean: yet in such wise that the Church is one thing, the doctrine another; just as the Ocean is one thing, the tide another. But what do the sectaries gain from this, whereby to shake our rule? Plainly nothing. For the Church can be known per se from the succession of pastors, and from public and due subordination; just as the Ocean is known from its situation and its bed. Whence you understand how the Church can be searched out from other evidences than from doctrine, and, she being once possessed, the sincerity of the doctrine inferred; as the fathers assume, and as we, treading in their footsteps, prove.